



# CENTER FOR STRATEGIC LEADERSHIP U.S. ARMY WAR COLLEGE

INTERNATIONAL STRATEGIC CRISIS

# ISCNE

NEGOTIATION EXERCISE



## Central Asia Scenario



UNITED STATES ARMY  
WAR COLLEGE

## The International Strategic Crisis Negotiation Exercise

### Exercise Description and Guidance

#### Introduction

The International Strategic Crisis Negotiation Exercise (ISCNE) uses experiential learning to educate participants in the process of crisis negotiations at the international/strategic level.

Participants, as part of a delegation, will be challenged in leadership styles, negotiating techniques, and communications abilities to reach their team's desired end-state. Each delegation engages with counterparts, within the framework of a United Nations conference, to try to resolve a long-standing and potentially volatile crisis. An actual complete resolution to the presented issues is not an expectation, nor is it a reality. Delegations will have to contend with teams that each have their own desired end-state goals.

The crisis being exercised is over the Central Asia region. Countries with interests in this region and involved in the negotiations are China, India, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Russia, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan. A Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Central Asia (SRSG) represents the UN. They will monitor developments, mediate negotiations and discussions, and report findings.

The key documents provided are the Central Asia Scenario, Privileged Instructions, and relevant reference documents. As the name implies the Privileged Instructions are protected communications from each government to their negotiation delegations regarding the impending round of talks and need to be handled as such.

This type of exercise works best when conducted within the confines of a strict schedule. This allows the parties involved time to negotiate issues, pause to evaluate and adjust their negotiation strategies, and schedule and respond to negotiation requests. The structure may induce some frustration, but this is not unrealistic. Within the context of this exercise all parties have accepted a UN negotiation model which establishes the structure and employs a control group concept.

#### Preparation for the Exercise

It is highly recommended that each delegation find time to meet and prepare prior to the exercise.

##### **Each delegation must have both a Head of Delegation (HOD) and a Team Communicator.**

As the title implies, the HOD is the delegation lead. This person is responsible for providing direction to the delegation and is responsible to their superiors, in the form of their Foreign Minister/Secretary (FM/S) as role-played by the Senior Controller. Which negotiation sessions the HOD elects to attend (or not to attend), is symbolic of their significance within diplomatic circles.

The Team Communicator is a full team member that has the additional duty of being the delegation's point of contact with the exercise control team. They are responsible for requesting and processing ad hoc negotiation invitations, team-to-team communication and diplomatic communiques as detailed below. This duty is critical for exercise execution.

#### Exercise Operations

As part of the United Nations' efforts, all parties agreed to the imposition of certain predetermined sessions and control mechanisms to ensure the proper conduct of the negotiations. For that purpose, a UN Control Group (UNCG) has been established, as the technical and administrative branch of the

## NOTIONAL EXERCISE MATERIAL FOR EDUCATIONAL PURPOSES ONLY

SRSg, to help manage the conduct of this peace conference and ensure implementation of the agreed mechanisms. These mechanisms are:

- **Ad Hoc Negotiation Scheduling:** Ad Hoc negotiation sessions are scheduled via an electronic system accessed by your delegation's communicator (not by direct delegation-to-delegation communication). Ad Hoc sessions must adhere to the negotiation periods set out in the exercise schedule. Sessions may be bilateral or multilateral and may be requested for 15- or 30-minute increments. Invited parties may *accept*, *decline*, or *ignore* the invitation. Once all invitees have responded, the system notifies all parties on whether the session will be held and if so, where. **Ad Hoc Negotiation Sessions only happen if all parties agree to attend.** A delegation may request and schedule as many negotiation sessions as it can support within the allotted time. **If you accept an invitation, you must attend the session.**

The SRSg will be available to meet with delegation(s) during Ad Hoc Negotiation sessions. All requests to meet with the SRSg are initiated in the same manner as ad hoc negotiation sessions. The SRSg has the option to call their own Ad Hoc Negotiation sessions; if so, these requests **cannot** be declined or ignored.

- **Diplomatic Communiqués:** These are messages to your nation's leadership to either provide reports or to request guidance. The Senior Controller will provide his cell phone number to the Head of Delegation and Team Communicator so that they can text him directly. If a delegation would like to meet with him, he will come to your team room during Team Meeting periods.
- **Team-to-Team Communication:** Delegations are allowed to communicate with each other as they determine appropriate but **may not conduct negotiations outside of formally scheduled negotiation sessions.**
- **Exercise Schedule:** Adherence to the exercise schedule will be strictly enforced. Team Meeting periods are an extremely important element, they are a time for internal team communication, evaluation of positions of the other delegations, consultation with their FM/S, scheduling negotiation sessions, and establishing talking points for the next round of negotiations. Negotiations between delegations can only take place during the scheduled negotiation periods.

### Conduct of the Exercise

The exercise begins following the exercise overview brief. At the opening plenary session, chaired by the SRSg, role-playing portion of the exercise begins. Participants should remain in role throughout. Negotiation sessions and team meetings are confidential but conversations in common or public areas are subject to intelligence collection.

***For the opening plenary each delegation should be prepared to present a 2-3 minute opening statement.*** Upon conclusion of the plenary participants will move to their team rooms and prepare for the commencement of negotiations. The first negotiation is pre-scheduled bilateral sessions. Thereafter, all sessions will be Ad Hoc, conducted as described above. The first day concludes with an internal team evaluation of the day's events.

The second day begins with a Team Meeting period followed by the resumption of negotiations. At the end of the day teams will reassemble for a closing plenary chaired by the SRSg. *During the closing plenary each delegation will brief their current positions, assess the progress made, and offer options for any proposed way forward.* Specific instructions on the closing plenary will be sent to each delegation during the last Ad Hoc negotiation session. At the conclusion of the plenary participants will come out of role and the Army War College will facilitate an after-action review.

INTERNATIONAL STRATEGIC CRISIS NEGOTIATION EXERCISE

## ***Central Asia Scenario***



The scenario utilized for this exercise depicts the dynamic geological and geopolitical rising tensions in Central Asia. The scenario's purpose is to provide a near real world situation and set the stage for delegation team negotiations which are the primary actions of the exercise.

The scenario is completely hypothetical and has been designed solely as an aid to achieve participant educational learning objectives. All materials in this exercise are notional for educational purposes only. There is no attempt to be predictive or reach a real-world solution.

*Read and understand the materials in this priority and order:*

- |              |                                                                     |
|--------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Required:    | Your Delegation's Privileged Instructions (separate document)       |
|              | Recent Significant Events (p. 2-3)                                  |
|              | Publicly Held Positions (pp. 4-5)                                   |
|              | Negotiation Issues (pp. 8-15)                                       |
| Recommended: | Brief History (pp. 6-8)                                             |
|              | Central Asia Scenario References ( <a href="#">Reference Link</a> ) |

## Why Central Asia?

Long painted as the object of the “great game”, these states are independent actors in their own right. Let's avoid stereotypes often used by monoglot historians, imperialistic overtones, and the constant evocation of the Silk Road and the exotic. To borrow from Adeeb Khalid, the concept of the Silk Road relegates Central Asia to a pathway rather than a place of interest itself.

Overall, in Central Asia, there is a growing desire for regional integration and an uptick in diplomatic activity involving several outside powers, but especially China. Border conflicts endanger cooperation and border solutions would be mutually beneficial.

For example, cooperation over water resources in Central Asia is likely to have a “spill-over” effect: it can encourage regional cooperation in other areas, including economic development. In this sense, water sharing may encourage broader conflict prevention.

## List of Abbreviations

|             |                                                              |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>BRI</b>  | Belt and Road Initiative                                     |
| <b>EAEU</b> | Eurasian Economic Union                                      |
| <b>FV</b>   | Fergana Valley                                               |
| <b>GBAO</b> | Gomo-Badakhshan Autonomous Region                            |
| <b>GSI</b>  | China's Global Security Initiative                           |
| <b>HT</b>   | Hizb ut-Tahrir al-Islami or Hizb ut-Tahrir                   |
| <b>PLA</b>  | Chinese People's Liberation Army                             |
| <b>SCO</b>  | Shanghai Cooperation Organisation                            |
| <b>CSTO</b> | Collective Security Treaty Organization                      |
| <b>ICWC</b> | Interstate Commission for Water Coordination of Central Asia |

## Current Situation

The Fergana Valley (FV) is a densely populated agricultural basin that spans across Uzbekistan, Kyrgyzstan, and Tajikistan. Since the collapse of the Soviet Union, it has been one of Central Asia's most volatile regions due to its complex and contested borders, scarce water resources, land degradation, and the presence of religious extremism.

The valley's rich soil is nourished by the Syr Darya river, which is formed by the Naryn and Kara Darya rivers, making it a vital agricultural center. Surrounded by five mountain ranges, the FV contains strategic choke points that control water access for Batken, a district capital in Kyrgyzstan, and large areas of irrigated farmland in Tajikistan. Roughly 110 kilometers of the border in and around the valley remain in dispute.

Climate change is projected to worsen instability by increasing pressure on water and arable land. This is especially critical as agriculture utilizes approximately 90 percent of the surface water in Central Asia, forming the backbone of the region's food production and economy.

In addition to these environmental pressures, states in the region are also dealing with energy scarcity, religious extremism, and the potential for ethnic violence. The persistent conflict in the Fergana Valley continues to obstruct economic and social development throughout Central Asia.

Concerned that these disputes over territory and resources could escalate into a larger crisis, the United Nations has invited delegations from each country to a summit to negotiate a resolution.

## Recent Significant Events

(\*Notional Events)

### 2021

**November:** China agrees to fund an outpost in the tumultuous Gorno-Badakhshan Autonomous Region, next to China's north-western Xinjiang region, to be manned by Tajik personnel.

### 2022

**January 6:** For the first time ever, the CSTO agrees to intervene in Kazakhstan with a collective group of so-called "peacekeeping" forces due to the unrest in Kazakhstan.

**January 27:** Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi presides over the India-Central Asia Summit with all five Central Asian heads of state present.

**February 18:** ICWC 30-year anniversary.

**September 14-17:** Large-scale clashes between Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan in which both countries fail to observe international humanitarian law during the conflict, leading to civilian deaths.

**October 9:** Kyrgyzstan refuses to hold CSTO Exercise "Indestructible Brotherhood-2022," which were scheduled to occur in the Issyk-Kul region from October 10-14, 2022, citing "bad blood."

**October 11:** Kyrgyzstan announces its refusal to take part in the CSTO Rubezh-2022 exercises in Tajikistan. Rubezh-2022 took place October 17-21, 2022.

**November 3:** Kyrgyzstan agrees to cede to Uzbekistan the territory surrounding the Kempir-Abad Reservoir, covering 4,485 hectares, in exchange for over 19,000 hectares elsewhere, effectively giving Tashkent control of the reservoir.

**December 22:** Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan sign Treaty on Allied Relations, which includes provisions whereby the parties take measures for the rational use of transboundary water resources and the operation of water management structures, as well as the implementation of water-saving technologies.

### 2023

**June:** Kyrgyz authorities temporarily institute strict protocols in Bishkek on water use during a severe drought, including watering home gardens. Kazakhstan faces small protests over similar measures in Astana, while Aktau declares a state of emergency over the Caspian sea.

**July 20:** Kyrgyz authorities declare a three-year energy emergency, set to last until December 2026.

### 2024

**January 1:** Kazakhstan assumed the three-year chairmanship of the ICWC.

**February 6:** State authorities from Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan announce they have delimited another stretch of their border.

**May 7:** Conflict between Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan: Cattle breeders from Tajikistan allegedly graze their herd on Kyrgyz territory. Border guards order the herders to leave, shots are exchanged, and one Tajik is reportedly injured in the gunfire.

**June 19:** The Kyrgyz Parliament ratifies an agreement for the construction of the China-Kyrgyzstan-Uzbekistan railway.

**July 3-4:** Astana hosts the 24<sup>th</sup> Summit of the Council of Heads of State of the SCO.

## **2025**

**March 13:** Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan concluded a landmark border agreement.

**March 31:** Uzbekistan joined Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan to complete a border agreement in the Fergana Valley.

**November 6:** United States President Donald Trump hosted the heads of the five Central Asian countries for their annual summit. The group is known as C5+1 and was formed in 2015.

**December 10\*:** The Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Central Asia agrees to host a Central Asia dialog conference at the UNRCCA Headquarters in Ashgabat, Turkmenistan.

## **2026**

**February 6\*:** Delegations arrive in Ashgabat from China, India, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Russia, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan. The Central Asia dialog conference is set to begin in the afternoon.

## Publicly Held Positions

### China:

China has solidified its position as Central Asia's primary economic partner, leveraging the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) to heavily invest in regional infrastructure and boost trade. This economic engagement has seen trade with the five Central Asian nations more than double since 2013. While China and Russia are partners in the SCO and share a stated goal of countering Western influence, their relationship is marked by competition. Chinese investment in the region has surpassed Russia's, and Beijing is expanding its strategic influence through both economic policies and security engagements. President Xi Jinping is actively promoting China's Global Security Initiative (GSI), which aims to strengthen the security capabilities of Central Asian states to protect Chinese investments from terrorism and externally instigated "color revolutions."

### India:

India emphasizes its deep historical ties with Central Asia, which span several millennia. Through its "Extended Neighborhood Policy," New Delhi is actively working to enhance its economic and political influence by diversifying diplomatic partnerships and engaging with the region on multiple fronts. A key aspect of this strategy is its security relationship with Tajikistan, where it operates a foreign air base, while also maintaining close military ties with Russia. India is pursuing a multi-aligned approach, negotiating a free trade agreement with the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU) and joining the SCO in 2017. However, its participation in the SCO is complicated by its historically strained relationship with China. As Russia's regional influence declines, India remains cautious of China achieving hegemony in Central Asia.

### Kazakhstan:

As the largest economy in Central Asia, Kazakhstan champions a multi-vector foreign policy and is committed to strategic cooperation with its regional neighbors. While it maintains a vital economic and security partnership with Russia as a member of the CSTO, Astana has grown increasingly sensitive to Russian expansionist rhetoric. In response, Kazakhstan is emphasizing the need to foster stability, security, and progress throughout the region. Astana believes that strengthening regional solidarity is crucial for enhancing the collective agency of Central Asian states, especially given the region's post-independence history of trade disputes, border feuds, and resource disagreements. By boosting cooperation with its neighbors, Kazakhstan seeks to bolster its own position in Eurasia. However, persistent conflicts, such as the dispute over the Fergana Valley, continue to undermine these ambitions.

### Kyrgyzstan:

Kyrgyzstan is pursuing a multi-dimensional foreign policy, acknowledging that resolving its border disputes with Uzbekistan and Tajikistan is essential for regional peace. The country balances its relationships with major powers to maximize its geopolitical and economic gains. It maintains close security and economic ties with Russia as a member of the CSTO and EAEU and depends on remittances from Kyrgyz labor migrants. At the same time, Kyrgyzstan is increasingly aligned with China, which has become its largest trading partner and a significant investor in its metallurgy and green energy sectors. Internally, the nation faces a severe energy crisis. Despite being rich in minerals, it is heavily reliant on hydropower for up to 90% of its energy. This source is now unreliable after three consecutive years of drought. The country's mining sector has also contributed to water pollution. These mounting pressures on water and energy make resolving the Fergana Valley conflict a critical priority for Kyrgyzstan as it seeks to provide for its population.

**Russia:**

Russia views Central Asia as its "*bližneye zarubežye*" or "*near abroad*," a concept underpinning its assertion of a privileged sphere of influence in the post-Soviet space. This perspective is often accompanied by colonialist and expansionist rhetoric from Russian elites, with hostile language increasingly mirroring that used against Ukraine prior to its invasion. Militarily, Russia is the dominant force in the CSTO, maintaining bases in member states Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan. While aligned with China through the SCO and close military ties, this friendship is competitive, as Moscow remains wary of Beijing's growing influence in a region it has historically dominated.

**Tajikistan:**

Tajikistan seeks a resolution to the Fergana Valley conflict with its neighbors, Kyrgyzstan and Uzbekistan. Although these relationships have been marked by conflict, there has been some progress in border demarcation. Still grappling with the aftermath of a bloody civil war from 1992-1997, Tajikistan remains one of the poorest countries in the world and is heavily reliant on remittances from labor migrants in Russia. This economic precarity has led it to align with great powers for financial and security benefits. It is a member of the Russian-led CSTO, which operates a military base in the country. Simultaneously, Tajikistan has developed a close but debt-heavy economic relationship with China, which has expanded in recent years to include a paramilitary base and joint counterterrorism drills. Domestically, the government has increasingly turned to repressive measures under the stated aim of fighting religious radicalism, a persistent issue that adds another layer of complexity to the instability in the Fergana Valley.

**Turkmenistan:**

Turkmenistan strictly adheres to a foreign policy of "permanent neutrality," which keeps it officially disengaged from regional military and political blocs like the CSTO and SCO. This neutral stance shapes its interactions with global powers, allowing it to maintain transactional relationships without formal alliances. The nation's economy is overwhelmingly dependent on its vast natural gas reserves, making China its most critical partner as the primary destination for its energy exports via the Central Asia-China pipeline. This focus on neutrality and bilateral energy deals means Turkmenistan remains largely detached from multilateral efforts to resolve regional conflicts like those in the Fergana Valley. Its primary security concern is the stability of its long, porous border with Afghanistan, which necessitates a pragmatic and cautious approach to foreign policy. While it maintains economic ties with Russia, its deep energy dependence on Beijing and its official neutrality limit Moscow's influence compared to its role in neighboring states.

**Uzbekistan:**

Uzbekistan is rapidly shedding its past as a hermit nation under President Shavkat Mirziyoyev, now pursuing an open, "multi-vector" foreign policy. As one of only two double-landlocked countries in the world, its goal is to foster good relations with its neighbors and avoid entanglement in great power competition. This pivot is driven by the desire to capitalize on initiatives like China's BRI, which requires regional cooperation. While Uzbekistan remains Central Asia's second-largest natural gas producer and a key supplier to China, recent domestic shortages have compelled it to import energy from Russia. Its relationship with the Russian-led CSTO is ambivalent, currently holding observer status, which underscores its preference for strategic autonomy. However, unresolved disputes over water resources in the Fergana Valley present a major obstacle to its ambitions, posing a constant risk of renewed conflict.

## Brief Historic Background

The heritage of Central Asia is rich. Its ancient history is long and complicated. Early human societies found nomadism to be the way of survival in the steppe climates. River valleys and oases produced more sedentary agricultural societies.

Large-scale migration, invasions, and conquests have marked Central Asia since antiquity. The Persians, the Turks, the Mongols, Muscovy, the Russian empire, and the Soviet Union have all held power in various parts of the region. Their legacies, in one way or another, continue to shape the ethnic, social, political, and religious dynamics of Central Asia.

Religiously, Zoroastrianism had a long foothold in the region following the rise of the priest Zarathustra, sometime between 1800 BCE and 1200 BCE in modern-day Afghanistan. The region's conversion to Islam was a multi-generations long process but eventually became an important center of Islam, producing some of the world's greatest luminaries.

From 800 to 1100 CE, Central Asia was the hub of world culture, contributing significantly to civilizations across the globe. The Silk Road crisscrossed the region with major trade routes and produced lasting cultural and intellectual achievements in various fields of the arts and sciences.



Genghis Khan

By 1100 CE, the environment had changed from a culture influenced by many religions to one increasingly dominated by Islam. Finally, serious fractures within Islam itself began to assume a greater importance. These divisions continue to influence policy and social life in the region today.

The Mongol Empire ruled over most of Central Asia beginning in the 13<sup>th</sup> century. With the eventual breakup of the Mongol Empire, various independent khanates formed by Genghis Khan's descendants. By the end of the 15<sup>th</sup> century all these lands had fallen into the hands of the Uzbek people. With the rise of Russia in the 17<sup>th</sup> century they began to annex portions of Central Asia.

## Russian Imperial Conquest

Between 1800-1900, Central Asia became a battleground in the rivalry between imperial Britain and Tsarist Russia. For the Russians, the chief objective was to thwart British colonial expansion and gain access to a rich source of raw materials, particularly cotton, and create a colonial marketplace in which Russian goods could compete.

The Russian Empire's attention thus turned from Europe to Asia. Between the Congress of Vienna and the First World War, the Russian conquest of Central Asia can be considered a successful example of European imperial expansion, adding 1.5-million square miles and at least 6 million people to the Tsar's already considerable empire. From 1865 to 1924, Russian leaders used the term Turkestan to refer to the concrete administrative entity of Central Asia.



Russian Imperial Expansion

For Central Asia, the early incorporation into the Russian empire would have disastrous consequences for the indigenous cultures and religions. Policies of russification would chip away at language and religion in Central Asia.

Russian colonial power did not go without challenge from the Central Asian tribes. In 1916, a rebellion emerged as the Russian empire attempted to conscript Central Asian men for forced labor. Over 3,000 Russian settlers were killed in a series of attacks. This rebellion, the Basmachi movement, was an indigenous attempt to liberate Central Asian tribes from Russian conquest, led by Muslim priests and local feudal lords. The overwhelming military superiority of the Russians crushed this movement and the heavy-handedness with which this insurrection was dealt made for minimal opposition in the future.

It is estimated that around 150,000 Central Asians, mostly Kyrgyz, died at the hands of Russian retributive expeditions and settler vigilante violence. Far more Central Asians died from violence, famine and disease in the five years between the outbreak of the 1916 Revolt and the establishment of the Soviet Union in 1921 than during all the campaigns of conquest which had made Central Asia a part of the Russian empire over the previous 100 years.

### Russian Revolution

News of the Russian Revolution received positive reception in Central Asia. Their chance at freedom from Russian rule did not last long. General Mikhail Frunze, born in Kyrgyzstan to a Bessarabia father and Russian mother, eventually captured Uzbek cities Khiva and Bukhara in 1920. The Fergana Valley, however, was a stronghold of the Basmachi movement. The Red Army would not finally defeat the Basmachi's until 1926. Out of the chaos of the Russian Revolution, the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR) was born.

### Soviet Era

Soviet rhetoric obfuscated the imperialistic origins of Central Asian inclusion in the Soviet Union, instead emphasizing the "friendship of peoples", contributing to a Russian amnesia of its colonial past.

In the Soviet era, Russian imperialism and colonialism in Central Asia would be replaced by an experiment in nation-building. The borders of Central Asia came to the region through the advent of the Soviet Union, when the region, called Turkestan in Russia, was divided into the Tajik, Uzbek, Turkmen, Kazakh, and Kyrgyz Soviet Socialist Republics (SSR).

The Soviet demarcation strategy left the Tajik, Kyrgyz, and Uzbek SSR borders in an interlocking manner, and these borders were informed by multiple sources of information: late-Tsarist and early-Soviet census data, ethnographic and orientalist scholarship, as well as *raionirovanie* (районирование), the process of making rational and economically functioning units to ensure the viability of these new SSRs. Given the multilingual and multiethnic nature of the region and the mixed livelihoods that the local population led, this was more than a difficult task. The result is the intricately designed map we see today. Borders between Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, and Uzbekistan are being demarcated still today.



"Water soil and it will feed you" Uzbek, 1920

## Collapse of Soviet Union and Independence

As a result of the failed reforms implemented in the second half of the 1980s, many SSRs', with the notable exception of Central Asia, requests for increased autonomy occurred at the same time and in a rapid way that had the effect of undermining the communist and Soviet regimes. These demands coupled with mass demonstrations and an ideology crisis played a crucial role in the collapse of the USSR. Unlike their European counterparts, like the Baltic nations, the Central Asian SSRs had even strongly advocated for the continuation of the Soviet Union. The breakup of the USSR led to the then Soviet leaders in each Central Asian SSR retaining their power.



New York Times Front Page Dec. 26, 1991

When the Soviet Union collapsed, the Central Asian states were thus thrust into independence. Enforcement of borders had not mattered up until that point, suddenly borders existed where commingling had been the norm. The complex transition process has not been a linear story but a bumpy road with ups and downs. Today these post-Soviet countries still struggle with the transition or have moved from a model of Soviet authoritarianism to a national one.

## Negotiation Issues

### Regional Security Considerations

Today, Russia views Central Asia as its "*bližneye zarubežye*" or its "*near abroad*." This political language reflects Russian policies to the newly independent states of Central Asia as Russia believes itself to enjoy a privileged sphere of influence in the post-Soviet space. Moscow has pursued its economic and security objectives via bilateral arrangements with its neighbors or through new, modern-style regional organizations, like the Eurasian Economic Union (EEU), Russia, Armenia, Belarus, Kazakhstan, and Kyrgyzstan. The Collective Security Treaty Organization (CSTO) is a



CSTO Logo

political-military alliance, comprising Russia, Armenia (which recently announced its intentions to quit the union), Belarus, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Tajikistan. The CSTO is Russia's answer to NATO, meant to counter the West's influence. The Kremlin wishes to continue its role as a regional security provider as well as supplier of modern weapons to Central Asian countries. Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan have long depended on weapons donations from Moscow in return for hosting Russian military bases.

While this alliance was set up in a 1992 meeting in Tashkent, Uzbekistan is not a member. Its relationship with the CSTO can be described as hot and cold. It was a member from its establishment until 1999. It rejoined the CSTO in 2006 but left again in 2012. Experts believe there are no compelling indications that Uzbekistan is considering rejoining the alliance a third time. Turkmenistan adheres to a policy of "permanent neutrality," keeping it outside of these Russian-led economic and military blocs entirely, thereby limiting Moscow's multilateral influence within its borders.

## History of Russian Abstentions and Interventions

The CSTO has not been active in protecting the security interests of its members. During the 2010 ethnic clashes that broke out in southern Kyrgyzstan between ethnic Kyrgyz and Uzbeks, Then interim Kyrgyz President Roza Otunbayeva requested the presence of CSTO forces to intervene in the conflict and stabilize the situation on the ground. CSTO and Russian officials declined, citing their refusal on the organization's lack of mandate to intervene in the domestic affairs of its members, a provision which has not lasted.

The only CSTO intervention to ever occur was in January 2022 in Kazakhstan, following violent domestic unrest in the country. This event, known as Bloody January, was unexpected as Kazakhstan was the example of a stable autocracy. What started out as protests over rising fuel costs descended into questioning the country's regime and violent riots. CSTO forces, mainly Russians soldiers, did not suppress protests but instead protected key assets. The CSTO reportedly did not fire a single shot and after the protests died down, the forces left Kazakhstan. It can be considered that the intervention was symbolic, preserving the rule of Kazakh President Tokayev and showing that the CSTO still had life. President Tokayev knows now that his position – and the position of the wider Kazakh political elite – is reliant on active Russian support.

Finally, while China wants Russia to play by the rules, this case of CSTO intervention in Kazakhstan largely benefited both Russia and China. Both view protest movements as suspect, believing that they may lead to larger "color revolutions".

The CSTO did not, however, involve itself in one of the most recent episodes of conflict between Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan in September 2022. With two members of the CSTO engaged in open armed conflict, at least 80 Kyrgyz lives were claimed and more than 100,000 (140,000 by some estimates) people in Kyrgyzstan were temporarily displaced. Military and civilian infrastructure on both sides of the border was destroyed. Human Rights Watch research indicates both countries failed to observe international humanitarian law during the 4-day conflict, leading to civilian deaths.

The persistence of this long-standing conflict between Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan presents a challenge for the CSTO. First, the CSTO lacks any proper mechanisms that address conflicts between its member-states, and second, any attempts to put forward a resolution in the border issues between Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan would invariably produce more complicated and unpredictable outcomes that could likely go beyond a bilateral dispute and deepen mistrust. The conflict between the two member states is a slippery slope issue for the CSTO. For the Kremlin, any CSTO involvement in this dispute could have adverse implications for the organization.

## China Rising

Another regional security body looms large. The Chinese-led Shanghai Cooperation Organization focuses its military cooperation on anti-terrorism and, as a vehicle for Chinese security involvement in Central Asia. Originally composed of the PRC, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan, and Uzbekistan. Its focus, like that of the CSTO, excludes becoming involved in conflicts between member states.



SCO Logo

It has been used to fund the internal security apparatus of, for example, Tajikistan. Like China, Tajikistan is obsessed over its fight against religious radicalism and other destabilizing factors. The return to power of the Taliban in Afghanistan is particularly concerning as Tajikistan shares its largest border with the country. Partnering with the PRC on security initiatives is ideal as China is similarly focused on eradicating radicalism and subjugating its Muslim populations in Xinjiang.

In 2022, the PRC agreed to provide funding to build a paramilitary base for Tajik forces in Tajikistan. The construction of a paramilitary base in Gorno-Badakhshan Autonomous Region (GBAO) would belong to the Tajik Ministry of Internal Affairs and focus on counterterrorism efforts. The GBAO is a site of concern for the nation and viewed as the hotspot of radicalism.

There have been rumors of a Chinese base in Tajikistan for many years. Fears of the porous borders of Afghanistan and Tajikistan had also allegedly led to a secret agreement between both countries and Beijing. This 2019 reported agreement granted China the right to repair or expand 30 to 40 preexisting outposts on the Tajik side of the border.

### **India Rising or Stalling?**

While India joined the SCO in 2017, its relations with China have historically been strained. India prefers a strong Russia and has appreciated its support of New Delhi's Eurasian ambitions. Fast forward to today, Russia's position has changed within the SCO. Moscow continues to weaken and as its leadership of the group slips, China is picking up the slack. India's interest in the organization may be waning, and the nation enjoys close ties with Russia and the Central Asian states independent of the group. In 2023, India held chairmanship of the SCO and chose to convene the meeting online. In 2024, Prime Minister Narendra Modi skipped the summit in Astana.

India maintains two foreign air bases in Tajikistan, with the aim of increasing India's heft in Central Asia and acting as a counterweight to China's ambitions. The Ayni Air Base (also known as Gissar Military Aerodrome), once used by U.S. air force planes for refueling for its missions in Afghanistan, is located close to Dushanbe. India began its renovations on the runways and hangars in the aughts and was meant to be operational come 2006. In 2010, reports indicated the air base was largely dormant, with no fighter jets to be seen. Many political analysts saw this delay being due to Moscow's implicit prohibitions on another country maintaining an airbase in its "near abroad". Come 2015, India's effective use of Ayni was still under speculation. The airbase has thus far publicly only been used to evacuate Indian citizens from Afghanistan in 2021. The Farkhor air base is located about 80 miles south of the Tajik capital and is strategically situated at the Tajik-Afghan border.

The recent history of India-Central Asia engagements has been largely focused on security cooperation due to shared fears of Afghanistan's instability and religious extremism. In March 2023, New Delhi hosted the first meeting of the Joint Working Group on Afghanistan as part of the Central Asia-India Dialogue. The five Central Asian states gathered to discuss the threats from its neighbor and countering regional security challenges, including terrorism and extremism.

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### **Extremism Concerns**

Islamic opposition groups have a long history; however, in contrast to the Middle East, North Africa regions, specifically, violent extremism and insurgency is not as endemic. There are historical examples such as the Basmachi movements opposed to Russian expansion. Additionally, the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan in 1979, in which some Central Asian Muslims were engaged in military campaigns, saw their reflection of the mujaheddin against their own struggle.

Following the collapse of the Soviet Union, concerns of violent extremism heightened in Central Asia. Faltering political and economic reforms, mounting social problems, government abuses and corruption, suppression of religious freedom and constraints on opposition forces became a fertile breeding ground for radical groups.

After the collapse of the Soviet Union, two primary actors arose as a significant terror threat to the region: the Islamic Jihad Union (IJU) and the Islamic Movement of Uzbekistan (IMU). In the late nineties, Uzbekistan, Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan experienced raids and attacks by forces of the IMU, which became affiliated with the Taliban. Uzbek President Islam Karimov named the group as being responsible for nearly killing him in a 1999 bombing attack. The United States' invasion of Afghanistan drastically changed the landscape in the region and temporarily restrained the IMU and IJU. In 2015, though its power diminished, IMU became affiliated with Islamic State Khorasan Province (ISIS-K).

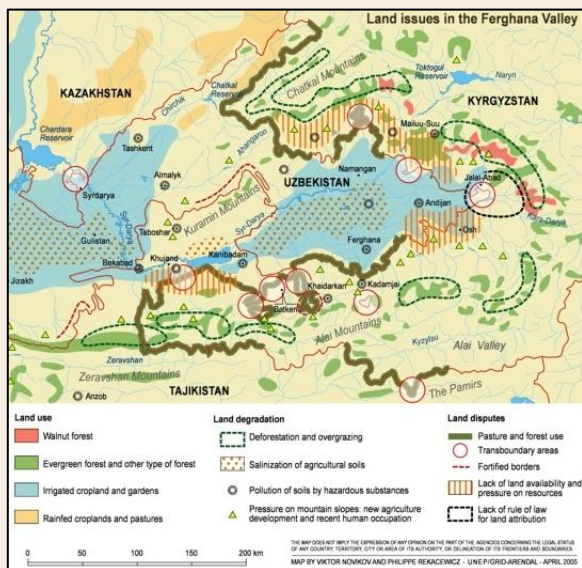
Tajikistan has been additionally vulnerable to terror cells because of its civil war from 1992 to 1997, which killed some 150,000 people. The war saw nationalists, democrats and Islamists unite in fighting against the autocratic regime of Tajik President Emomalii Rahmon. After its conclusion, the Islamic Resistance Party of Tajikistan (IRPT) was guaranteed positions in the government and seats in the parliament as part of a peace agreement that ended the civil war. However, in 2015, President Rahmon declared the IRPT a terrorist organization. As Tajikistan continues to be governed by a corrupt authoritarian regime in which all religious activity is surveilled and repressed, and political rights nonexistent, the risk of radicalization remains ever present.

In the wake of the Taliban takeover of Afghanistan in August 2021, ISIS-K seized the opportunity to establish a presence in Central Asia. Media outlets affiliated with ISIS-K produce content in the Tajik language and their activities have yielded results, attacks with deadly consequences in Tajikistan and several other countries. Most recently, the attack on Moscow Crocus City Hall, was attributed to Tajiks affiliated with ISIS-K. ISIS, the parent organization, is continuing to allow the decentralization of power and while Europe may have been the focus in the past, the organization may continue to carry out attacks in Central Asia, Russia, and beyond.



Crocus City Hall Attack

## Water Sharing



Fergana Valley

At the end of the 19th century, new irrigation technologies were introduced to Central Asia to cultivate cotton and other irrigated crops on a larger scale, in part to pick up the slack of the United States, whose production suffered during the American Civil War. The establishment of the USSR saw massive initiatives launched to "tame nature", such as the Virgin Lands Campaign. These efforts, including the introduction of monocultural farming and the centralization of irrigation systems management, were designed with the intention to boost the agricultural capabilities of the Soviet Union. This had unintended consequences on the region, leading to what many call the worst man-made

ecological catastrophe, the erasure of the Aral Sea. The loss of the sea demonstrates visible the stakes of water sharing for Central Asia.

During the period of Soviet rule, administrative borders between the republics were not important when designing water-supply systems and infrastructure – many canals and irrigation systems crisscross boundaries. While the “friendship of peoples” may have been the Soviet byline, conflicts over water existed even during the USSR. These intensified after the bloc’s dissolution in 1991 and with the consequent change in natural resource management in the region, competition for water began to increase.

The Fergana Valley has been and continues to be the agricultural heartland of Central Asia. The Valley is fed by the Syr Darya river, comprising the Naryn and the Kara Darya rivers. The Naryn River starts in eastern Kyrgyzstan's high mountains of Tian Shan and flows hundreds of miles downstream to meet the Kara Darya, which starts from the Osh region of Kyrgyzstan. The FV is surrounded by 5 mountain ranges, by the northwest Chatkal and Kurama mountains, on the northeast by the Fergana Mountains, and on the south by the Alay and Turkestan ranges, which rise to more than 16,500 feet (5,000 meters).

The Amu Darya is Central Asia's other great transboundary river, serving as the lifeblood for Tajikistan, Afghanistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan. Originating in the Pamir Mountains, its waters are critical for agriculture in the downstream desert nations of Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan, which inherited a Soviet-era system of massive irrigation canals designed for cotton and wheat production. The most prominent of these, Turkmenistan's Karakum Canal, is one of the world's longest, diverting enormous volumes of water deep into the desert.

A significant and destabilizing factor is Afghanistan. As an upstream nation, it was never a party to the Soviet-era water-sharing agreements that still govern relations between the other Central Asian states. Now, with the construction of the massive Qosh Tepa Canal, Afghanistan plans to divert a substantial portion of the Amu Darya's flow to develop its own agriculture. This unilateral action poses a severe threat to the water security of Uzbekistan and Turkmenistan, creating a major source of regional tension for which no formal international treaty or resolution mechanism exists.



86<sup>th</sup> Meeting of the ICWC

Recognizing the need for cooperation over water resources in the region, the Interstate Commission for Water Coordination (ICWC) was established in 1992 as a collective body of Central Asian states acting based on equity, equality and consensus. It describes itself as the only interstate body established and authorized by the Heads of Central Asian states to make binding decisions on current and emerging issues related to interstate water allocation and use. The ICWC also runs a Scientific Information Centre (SIC), that trains water officials, and operates a comprehensive database that can be assessed by its member countries.

This body has proven ineffective in mediating the conflict over water resources. The ICWC is only entitled to focus on water division, and therefore cannot deal with agriculture and the energy sector, which consume the most water. Moreover, as ICWC decisions are made by consensus, means that solutions can remain in a state of paralysis when the interests of countries conflict.

## Conflict Over Water

The irrigation systems of the FV are primarily gravity operated, meaning issues occur between upstream and downstream dynamics. Disagreements of even violent conflicts arise during the main irrigation period from April to June over the use of the water resources between Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan.

The “Golovnoi Vodorazdel” has been a source of conflict. This watershed area distributes water between the three countries of the Fergana Valley, Tajikistan, Kyrgyzstan, and Uzbekistan. Golovnoi is located between a narrow strip of Kyrgyzstan separating the Tajik exclave of Vorukh from the rest of Tajikistan. The Golovnoi technically serves as a sluice, splitting a river – known as Ak-Suu by the Kyrgyz and Isfara by the Tajiks. The sluice diverts a portion of the river water through a canal to the Tortkul (also known as Tortgul) Reservoir. The sluice has a road covering it, manned by soldiers of both Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan.

The Kyrgyz government considers the Reservoir to be an “object of strategic importance” and it irrigates thousands of hectares of Kyrgyz farms. Meanwhile, farms on the Tajik side of the border also reportedly depend on water that runs from the reservoir downstream to mainland Tajikistan, via the Golovnoi.

Most of these borderlands’ water resources are held in the Isfara River and the Tortkul Reservoir, which is of immense importance to farming communities on both sides of the border.

Prior to 2014, border incidents typically only involved residents arguing or in rarer cases, throwing stones. This changed in January 2014, when a conflict erupted over road construction on the Kyrgyz side, which Tajiks speculated would lead to Kyrgyz authorities closing the road connecting the Vorukh exclave with 30,000 Tajik residents to mainland Tajikistan. This conflict saw the use of heavy ammunition, mortar shells, and rocket-propelled grenades. Further down the line, in September 2019, four border guards were reported killed in cross-border exchange of fire. A May 2020 exchange of gunfire left several border guards injured. Then in April 2021 violence erupted after local Tajik authorities installed cameras on electric poles at the Golovnoi facility. In total 55 people died and tens of thousands were temporarily displaced.



Kyrgyz Soldier standing guard on the Golovnoi

The governments of Uzbekistan and Kazakhstan have previously offered to mediate in the dispute between Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan, with Almaty proposing to consider the development of a mechanism for settling border incidents at a regional level.

## Agricultural Drain on Water Resources

The agricultural sector is the largest employer in the Kyrgyz Republic, with about 40% of the labor force participating in this sector. Misuse and poor practices have resulted in the degradation of agricultural land while inadequate water management continues to hamper production.

Agriculture is the backbone of Tajikistan’s economy. Estimates are that the agriculture sector contributes 22.6% of the country's GDP while employing around half of the population. Half of Tajikistan’s territory is located at 9,850 feet (3,000 meters) above sea level, with mountains covering 93% of the country, leaving only a mere 7% of land that is suitable for farming. The World Bank estimates that more than 90% of agriculture production in Tajikistan is from irrigated lands.

The country is highly vulnerable to food insecurity and despite considerable effort and investment, access to clean drinking water remains a pressure point in the country, especially in rural areas.

Agriculture is an important sector of Uzbekistan's economy, accounting for approximately 25% of GDP and employing about 26% of the labor force. Agriculture consumes 90% of Uzbekistan's water resources. Uzbekistan's economy depends on white gold; from seed to textiles, the cotton industry employs about 30 percent of the workforce, according to GIZ. Uzbekistan uses three times more water than Egypt to produce one unit of GDP, five times more than Kazakhstan, and 74 times more than Australia, according to World Bank data.

Agriculture is a critical sector in Turkmenistan's economy, employing nearly half of the country's labor force and contributing significantly to its GDP. This agricultural activity consumes over 90% of the nation's water resources. Turkmenistan's economy is heavily dependent on its cotton and wheat production, sustained by one of the world's most ambitious and inefficient irrigation projects: the Karakum Canal. This massive canal stretches over 1,300 kilometers, and it is estimated that up to 50% of the water diverted from the Amu Darya is lost to evaporation and seepage before reaching the fields. This makes Turkmenistan one of the most water-intensive agricultural producers globally, a highly precarious position for a hyper-arid country facing increased competition over a dwindling water supply.

### **Tajik Hydropower**

Tajikistan's electricity production has since long been dependent on hydropower plants, most of which were built when Tajikistan was part of the USSR. Tajikistan ranks one of the highest in the world in hydropower potential per territorial unit. However, river flows in the winter period cannot generate sufficient hydropower to meet the increased electricity demands for residential heating, industrial production and to some extent agricultural needs.



Tajik President Emomali Rahmon at Roghun Dam

In October 2016, construction began on Tajikistan's largest hydropower investment to date: the Roghun Dam on the Vakhsh river. The project, when completed, would be a staggering 1100 feet (335 meters), the tallest dam in the world, and nearly double Tajikistan's electricity production. Downstream Uzbekistan grows cautious of completion of the dam, which is electricity stressed, but also water strapped.

This project, however, may be in jeopardy. Initially estimated to cost 4-billion USD, the project is now expected to cost nearly 6-billion USD. Roghun has thus far been financed with a combination of state

budget funds and borrowed money, the latter of which has been large for Central Asia's poorest country, reportedly outweighing spending on all other infrastructure projects. The country will be exploring possible avenues of financing to complete this project.

### **Kyrgyz Energy**

The International Trade Administration estimates that hydropower accounts for nearly 90% of electricity produced in the Kyrgyz Republic, but the installed capacity only represents about 10% of the country's hydropower potential. Three straight years of drought and reduced precipitation are making hydropower less reliable.

Hydro-based electricity production is susceptible to seasonal and weather-related fluctuations: electricity supply is therefore less reliable due to lower water inflows and high demand during the winter months. Furthermore, while demand centers are in the north, more than 80% of hydropower capacity is in the south of the country.

Kyrgyzstan has increasingly turned to China to help alleviate its energy woes, working on hydropower projects, while simultaneously going further into debt.

Since 2022, Kyrgyzstan has been floating the idea of nuclear power. In April 2024, Reuters released disturbing reports that dams holding back uranium waste were unstable. If the dams were disturbed by a landslide or earthquake, a Chernobyl-scale nuclear disaster threatens the whole of the Fergana Valley.

### **Aggravation of Climate Change on Shared Water Resources**

As global temperatures continue to rise, changes in seasonal patterns in water distribution have contributed to disagreements. Summer temperatures rising will trigger more frequent droughts, with the World Bank estimating that in Tajikistan alone, climate-related droughts could increase tenfold to over 30 percent by the end of the century. Glacier melt is expected to heighten the risks of flooding and mudslides across Central Asia.

Land degradation and desertification poses a significant transboundary risk to Central Asia. These issues can result in sand and dust storms, agricultural pests and diseases, like locusts and wheat blast, which would have devastating consequences for the region.

This aggravation combined with dilapidated infrastructure such as leaky pipes, poorly maintained canals, and outdated irrigation systems result in substantial water losses before it even reaches the intended farmland. This direct loss of water contributes to soil erosion and waterlogging in the surrounding areas, with scientists pointing to increased risks of water-related soil erosion as climate change progresses.

With an ever-growing population in economic and social decline, water management is a key issue in this conflict. Regional cooperation and collaborative adaptive management strategies over water resources are of paramount importance.



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